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Titan (Jewellery Division)

RURAL INITIATIVE: Gold Plus is the brand's vehicle to ride into rural homes. The sub-brand has grown by 90 per cent in terms of demand and volume in the last four years. The company organises trips to its showrooms and factories to educate the consumer on gold purity and branded jewellery.

RURAL SALES: Rs **420** crore

ALL INDIA SALES: Rs **2,800** crore



sumer Products Ltd (GCPL) will appoint 1,500 stockists in small towns and villages this year compared to the 500 last year. Given that 38 per cent of the company's revenues come from rural areas and are expected to touch 50 per cent this year, this is a smart move. Explains R.K. Sinha, chief operating officer of GCPL: "At present, we are directly present in 17,000 villages. By the end of this year we want to be present in 50,000 villages. Income levels in rural India have gone up in recent times and we are able to see the affluence through the increase in consumption of FMCG and consumer durable items."

While existing companies are increasing their reach, there are

others who want to build an emotional connect with the consumers by delivering tailor-made services to their doorsteps or even pocket, as in the case of Nokia. For most of rural India, a mobile phone is most often the very first gadget that they purchase, so it is seen as a magic box that offers information, connectivity and security. Nokia has tried to move up the value curve with the launch of Nokia LifeTools. Explains Jawahar Kanjilal, global head of emerging market services, Nokia: "While increasing our distribution in rural areas in India we discovered that the mobile phone was mostly the first gadget that a person ever owned, so they expected it to

change their lives. That helped us to come up with agricultural and educational service offerings that would help them in their day-to-day functioning." The company's LifeTools service offers the farming community information on weather conditions, mandi prices and even customised advisory on matters pertaining to crop protection. Priced attractively at Rs 30 per month, the subscription service will also offer educational tools like learning English and exam preparation through a question and answer exchange. The pilot that the company ran in Maharashtra has earned it a staunch brand ambassador in Jitendra Kore, a teacher in Kurh village who starts his day in school with a new word he has learnt from Nokia.

While demand for rural telephony has so far been driven by voice, players like Bharti Airtel are working on innovative value-added services. Given that rural areas are dealing with inefficiencies such as lack of adequate medical facilities and employment, value-added services can play an important role. Explains Raghunath Mandava, chief marketing officer (mobile services) of Bharti Airtel: "Text did not quite take off in the rural areas due to



Maruti Suzuki

RURAL INITIATIVE: *Ghar Ghar Mein* Maruti focuses on Panchayat members or village headmen, as they are opinion makers. Persuasive information is shared with them on buying a car. Maruti has appointed over 3,000 resident dealer sales executives for rural areas, who are from the local community and reach out to prospective buyers.

RURAL SALES: Rs **2,078** crore

ALL INDIA SALES: Rs **23,085** crore